

New Career Services Platform: UT Dallas is moving from Handshake to 12twenty

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Networking

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What is Networking?

Networking is the process of building relationships to explore career paths, learn about industries, and access opportunities that aren't always posted online. It includes connecting with friends, professors, alumni, and professionals to gain insights, not just job leads.

Deciding who can give you helpful information about your career field and creating those connections is a big part of the process. Moreover, networking is one of the most effective job search techniques that you can use. Many positions are never advertised, and networking is the best way to learn about these opportunities.

Make it your business to develop professional relationships with as many people as possible. Regardless of the stage of your career, the process of building a large number of contacts is invaluable when changing employment.

Need help with networking or preparing for an informational interview?

SCHEDULE AN APPOINTMENT

Networking & Informational Interviews

Video Guide



Watch on

NETWORKING VIDEO OVERVIEW 

NETWORKING VIDEO GUIDE 



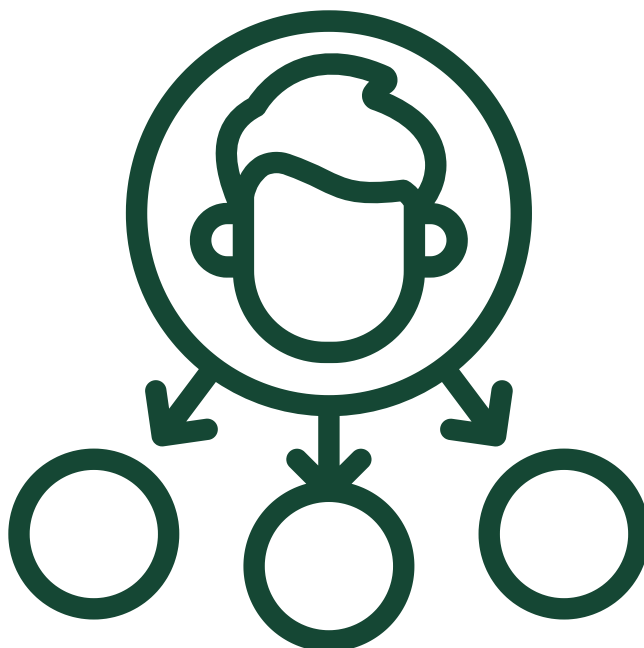
Make a Plan

- **Clarify your goals:** Start by understanding why you want to network—are you exploring, seeking advice, or researching companies?
- **Make a contact list:** Once you have figured out what your goals are start brainstorming who would be great to reach out to and connect with them. Start by making a list of who you already know (e.g. friends, classmates, professors, past employers, neighbors, etc.).
- **Choose your approach:** LinkedIn, emails, in-person or virtual networking events, on-campus employer events and information sessions.
- **Update your resume and LinkedIn profile before reaching out:** Make sure your resume is up-to-date so you can have it available to hand out as needed. Your LinkedIn profile should accurately reflect your accomplishments as well as feature a professional picture of yourself. You want your first impression to be a great one!
 - [Make an appointment](#) at the University Career Center for a professional headshot or meet with a Career Advisor for a LinkedIn or resume review.



Find Contacts

- **LinkedIn:** Use LinkedIn to find UT Dallas alumni or people working in roles you are interested in.
 - You can search by job title, and then filter by “People” to find professionals currently in this field.
 - Finding UTD alumni in your desired occupations is also a great strategy, since you have common ground as Comets.
- **Events & Workshops:** Attend networking events found on 12twenty or through student organizations related to your career interests (e.g. IEEE, AMSA, etc.). Many professional and student organizations frequently bring in guest speakers.
 - Collect business card and/or names and contact information from the individuals you meet so you can add them to your contacts list and connect with them on LinkedIn.
 - It is also a great idea to follow up afterward with an email or LinkedIn message simply stating that it was a pleasure to meet them and thanking them for the connection. You can also add something you learned from your interaction with them to make it more personal.
- **Faculty:** Reach out to your professors via office hours or email. Most faculty members are well-connected within their industry and are a great resource for connections.
 - Be prepared to provide them with your resume and specifics as to what type of connections, job titles, or company affiliations you are looking for so they can best assist you.





Asking for an Informational Interview

Informational interviews are excellent ways to get to know someone in a professional context. In this sort of interview, you will ask questions about the other person's work environment, job duties, and their background.

Informational interviews are key, because they show you to be someone who is interested in the field and invested in your own growth. They also are a bridge to help you connect with someone else without asking them for a favor that may be hard to grant right away, like a job referral.

It is best practice to plan what you are going to say to the professional you wish to interview in advance. It is imperative to include that you are only seeking information about the career field and not asking for a job interview.

- Keep your request short, polite, and focused on learning, not job offers.
- Be clear that you are seeking insight, not a job.

For example:

"Hi *[Name]*, I'm a student at UTD studying *[major]*, and I admire your path in *[industry]*. Would you be open to a 20-30 minute chat to share your experience?"

"Hello *[Name]*, my name is *[Your Name]* and I am a junior studying *[major]* at UT Dallas. I see that you are a successful *[job title]* at *[company]*. I would really appreciate hearing about your career journey and what it's like day-to-day in this role. Would you have time for a 30-minute call or meeting to discuss what it's like working in this industry?"

You should also mention if you have a mutual acquaintance or someone that referred you to this person in the initial outreach.



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Conducting a Successful Interview

- Prepare thoughtful questions about their career path, daily work, company culture, etc. Don't be afraid to refer to them.
- Take notes and stay curious. Ask open-ended questions to stimulate discussion and think genuinely about what you want to know. Keep it focused on the other person, but don't count on them to carry the conversation. An informational interview should be driven by your curiosity and desire to build a professional relationship; it's designed to foster a connection who may later desire to help you with a referral.
- Be conversational, not transactional. An informational interview should not be driven by a desire to convince someone why deserve to be at their company, and it is not designed to get you an instant referral.
- Start the interview centered on the person you are interviewing and their career path. If on-site, ask for a tour of the building and examples of their work. Take note of the work environment, ways people communicate, the dress, etc.
- If you have a resume, bring it with you. It would also be a good idea to send it to them prior to the interview. You may offer your resume to ask for feedback and what you should do to improve it.
- Remember to send a thank you note after the interview! Take some time to think about what you learned.

Q: *"If the conversation is focused on the other person, how will they get to know me?"*

A: As you ask good questions and hear about the other person's story, you will likely have opportunities to share about yourself as well. Remember that the goal is to learn about the other person and build the relationship that way.



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Maintain the Relationship

Networking is an ongoing process and rarely a one-and-done conversation. Keep a spreadsheet to keep up with your connections and interactions. Always follow up after your interactions, and set up calendar reminders to help remind you.

- Send a thank you message/email and make sure to mention something specific you learned from your conversation.
- Stay in touch once a month or quarterly.
- Share relevant updates or resources to keep the relationship active.

Here is an example of a spreadsheet:

Name	Employer	Email & Phone	How We Met	Most Recent Contact	Introduced Me To	Other Notes
Joe Schmoe	Environmental Protection Agency (same employer)	xyz@gmail.com 555-555-5555	My supervisor during 2L summer	Emailed update on October 12, 2025	John Doe	UTD Class of 1995. Provided me with reference letter.
Jane Doe	Sole Practitioner – Criminal Law & Family Law Practice	xyz@gmail.com 555-555-5555	Reached out through LinkedIn in January 2025	Had coffee on September 17, 2025	John Roe, Joan Doe	Always hiking in interesting places.
Joan Doe	Cavalluzzo (met at: United Steelworkers)	xyz@gmail.com 555-555-5555	Introduced by Jane Doe at bar association event in February 2025	Phone call on July 18, 2025	John Smith	Harvard Law Class of 2010. Told me to join the Labor & Employment Law Society.

Q: “How often do I need to follow up to keep the professional relationship going? Do I have to email every week?”

A: It is not necessary to chat with your new connection every week from here on out. Rather, consider following up once a month. You can provide something valuable, like an article relevant to their industry, or congratulations on achievements you learn of through their or their company's social media. Keep in mind the overall responsiveness of your new connection. You don't want to overwhelm them with messages.

Q: “When is a good time to ask my connection for a referral?”

A: There is no one best time to ask for a referral. The most important piece to keep in mind is that you will likely not get a referral if the person does not feel that they know you at all or can vouch for your abilities. So, focus on developing a professional relationship rather than trying to snag a referral as quickly as possible.



Potential Informational Interview Questions

About the Person

- What is your educational background?
- How did you get started in this field?
- How did you get to where you are today?
- What jobs did you have previous to this?
- What best prepared you for this job? Internships? Part-time jobs? Projects?

About the Job

- What do you do during a typical workday?
- What are the biggest challenges in your role?
- What do you like most about your work?
- Tell me about your experience working at your company.
- What skills or abilities do you find are most important in your work?
- What is something about this job that is different from what you expected before entering the field?

About the Career Field

- What are the basic skills and experiences needed for a job in this field?
- What is the typical working environment like for a person in this career area? What is a typical day like?
- How long does it usually take to move from one step to the next in this career path?

About Your Career Planning and Job

- Would you recommend any specific courses or activities to help prepare me for this field?
- Are there any resources you recommend I review or organizations I could join?
- Do you have any other advice or suggestions?
- Is there anyone you recommend I also connect with to help me learn more about this field?

Networking Tips to Remember

- Show genuine interest and share your value before asking for help to build trust.
- Focus on building relationships, not quick referrals.

- Follow up, but don't overwhelm your contacts.
- Be yourself and stay professional.

Networking with LinkedIn

Why Use LinkedIn?

With over a billion users in over 200 countries, [LinkedIn](#) is the world's largest professional networking platform. It connects professionals to create economic opportunity, support career growth, and facilitate job searching. Users can build their personal brand, showcase their experience and skills, network with others, and gain industry insights, making it a powerful tool for professional visibility and advancement.

LinkedIn acts as a tool for career advancement and job searching, serving as a digital hub for professional visibility, growth, and opportunity. By customizing your profile and personal branding, you can position yourself strategically for the role you want by effectively showcasing your strengths and skills to recruiters, hiring managers, and industry professionals. You can also gain valuable industry insight by following employer pages, joining groups, and more.

Setting Up Your LinkedIn Profile

Optimize Your Profile

The following are essential components of a strong LinkedIn profile:

- **Professional Headshot:** Your first impression to recruiters and viewers of your profile. Ensure your photo is professional, high quality, and presentable.
- **LinkedIn Banner:** Your LinkedIn banner is customizable and can reflect your personal brand, industry, or professional goals.
- **Headline:** Incorporate your job title, key skills, and relevant keywords to highlight your expertise.
- **Custom URL:** A custom URL replaces the default web address that is automatically assigned to new profiles, making your profile more professional and easier to share.
- Include any section that you can use to highlight your background and expertise, tailoring each section to align with your career goals and the roles you are targeting. Include the information you want recruiters to see.

Elevate your profile by highlighting these essential sections:

- **About:** The About section is one of the most frequently viewed sections on your profile and presents a key opportunity to showcase your skills, achievements, and professional journey.
- **Education:** Include your schools, degrees, relevant coursework, honors, and extracurricular activities to showcase your academic experience and skills.
- **Experience:** The Experience section highlights your work history, roles, and accomplishments to demonstrate your professional journey. Use bullet points with action verbs, highlight measurable achievements, and tailor descriptions to align with your career goals.
- **Skills:** Showcase your top skills and core competencies to help others understand your areas of expertise. Adding relevant skills to your profile increases your visibility to recruiters and strengthens your professional credibility.

Introduction Section: Profile Picture, Headline, Banner, and Contact Information

Custom LinkedIn URL

About Section

Experience Section

Education Section

Skills Section

Honors and Awards Section

Leveraging LinkedIn Features

Advance your career and grow your professional network by leveraging these features:

- **Job Search:** Use the Jobs tab to locate job or internship opportunities that align with your career goals. Users can receive job recommendations curated to the information included on their profile and can also apply directly through LinkedIn.
- **Networking:** Interact with professionals across industries to build strong relationships, gain industry insights, and discover new opportunities.
- **Alumni Finder:** LinkedIn's Alumni Finder allows you to search for people who attended your alma mater. Connecting with alumni offers great benefits, such as accessing insider industry insights, mentorship opportunities, potential job referrals, and insight into career paths from professionals who share the same educational background.
- **Posting:** Build your professional brand by sharing insights, achievements, or industry trends that showcase your experience and expertise. Posting or interacting with others' posts can lead to new networking connections, job opportunities, and increased visibility in your field.

Make the most of your LinkedIn account with these tips:

Job Search

Alumni Groups

Reaching Out On LinkedIn

Building Your Brand

Networking Tips & Strategies

LinkedIn Etiquette

Your LinkedIn profile often serves as the first place a recruiter, hiring manager, or client “meets” and “gets to know” you. It represents y our professional self and includes aspects like first impressions, professional image, and overall representation. It is important to use LinkedIn with professionalism, courtesy, and awareness of proper etiquette.

Personalizing Connection Requests

Messaging & Thank You’s

Interacting with Recruiters

Posts & Content

LinkedIn vs. Resume

While both a LinkedIn profile and resume are important professional documents used in job searching, they serve different purposes and have distinct key differences.

Here are some of the key differences at glance:

Feature	LinkedIn	Resume
Purpose	Personal branding, networking, visibility	Targeted job application
Audience	Recruiters, peers, connections	Specific employers or recruiters
Length	No limit	Usually 1–2 pages
Tone	Blend of casual and professional	Formal, clear and concise
Content Breadth	Broad – including all career aspects	Narrow – relevant experiences only
Media	Links, images, videos	Usually text only
Customization	One version	Multiple versions; customized
Updates	Continuous updates	Updated as needed

Additional Information

If a recruiter receives your resume and is interested, they will often visit your LinkedIn profile to learn more about you for the following reasons:

- To verify what is on your resume
- To check skills or experience
- To learn about your career path
- To assess cultural fit

- To engage or reach out
- To assess your professionalism
- To see mutual connections
- To gauge engagement or involvement

The University of Texas at Dallas

University Career Center

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800 W. Campbell Road
Richardson, Texas 75080-3021

972-883-2943

EVENTS

- OCT 6

UCC - Comet Trek (Employer Site Visit) with Medpace
- OCT 7

UCC- Deep Ellum Foundation Tabling
- OCT 7

UCC: CVS Health Information Session
- OCT 8

UCC- Teach for America Tabling
- OCT 8

UCC: Fifth Third Bank- Panel and Networking Event



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Career Center
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7.3K

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UT DALLAS

2027 INTERNSHIP PROGRAM

The Texas Credit Union summer internship program is open for current Sophomores and Juniors interested in the financial services, commercial banking and credit industries with a focus on:

- Data Analytics
- Project Management
- Technology

This is a paid internship opportunity. Details at [utd.link/41n](#)

UCC

Meet the Business

October 8, 2026 - SSB 3.300

Risk 101 Breakfast

10:30-11:30 a.m.

Join leaders and experts about career opportunities across Risk 101. Breakfast provided.

Register at [utd.link/41n](#)

Internal Audit

12-1 p.m.

Join the team for professional and career guidance from the Internal Audit team.

Register at [utd.link/41n](#)

IACU

Your Way to Career Success

Stop by your residence hall lobby for free breakfast tacos and career advice from the University Career Center.
Andreswade, Capella, & Vega & Silvia Hall
Halls Hall
10/8, 8:00 a.m. - 10/9, 8:30 a.m.
[utd.link/41n](#)



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